and Yogi is deployed to aggressively push for a consolidation of the Hindu vote bank across the country." Yogi has already assumed that mantle in the first term, campaigning for the BJP in many states and steadily building a pan-Indian presence—that process can only accelerate.

CAN YOGI DO A MODI?

Can Yogi rise from being an effective chief minister to prime minister as Modi had done? Gupta of Axis My India believes any political leader aspiring to repeat Modi's success needs to have three essential qualities that the prime minister possesses. The first is to have unquestioned acceptance in the party organisation and gain full control over it. The second is to have a vision for the country, and be able to get policies executed by the bureaucracy. This requires not just the bandwidth to comprehend the different areas of governance but also the management skills to get past the stubborn babudom. The third, and this Gupta believes to be a key attribute, is to develop a deep connect with the electorate, winning hearts both through words and actions. Rakesh Sinha, a BJP Rajya Sabha MP and strategist, says it unapologetically: "Modiji made the party a truly grassroots one and we are in power because of his charisma and vision. He ushered in a saffron revolution by creating a consensus between the Mandal vs Kamandal groups so that they are no more in conflict with each other. It is a new era in politics."

Many political observers believe that Yogi still has a long way to go before he can become a national leader in the Modi mould. Sudheendra Kulkarni, who served as advisors to both A.B. Vajpayee and L.K. Advani, doesn't think Yogi has what it takes to make it to the top. "I don't see him becoming a national leader because he lacks the main qualities that pushed Modi to the centre stage," he says. "Modi had a broader appeal among people outside of the Hindu vote. He propagated a Gujarat model of governance, which he popularised. Moreover, Yogi is nowhere near Modi in terms of being an effective communicator." Another party observer is as blunt. "Yogi won UP on the strength of Modi's charisma. Take Modi out of the equation, and you think Yogi can win even a simple majority in UP on his own? It is better he focuses on delivery for the state rather than nurture national ambitions."

Others see a limit to the process of consolidation of the Hindu vote bank, and therefore of pursuing an aggressive Hindutva agenda. Election strategist Prashant Kishor believes the BJP has never been able to consolidate the Hindu vote beyond 50 per cent of the total Hindu population in most elections (around 40 per cent of the total electorate). He touts Mamata Banerjee's decisive victory in West Bengal in the face of the BJP electoral juggernaut as proof of that. There is only that much electoral dividend religious polarisation can deliver. That is why Modi, the BJP and RSS have included nationalism and welfarism in the mix, along with playing the caste card where it suits them. Gupta, too, thinks there are limitations to the Hindutva vote and that it needs to be supplemented by a development and governance agenda. Yet others believe that the BJP has fulfilled most things the RSS was vociferous about after coming to power in 2014. This included abrogating Article 370, building the Ram Mandir and pushing for a uniform civil code. It now needs to find new ways of winning rather than just focusing on expanding the Hindu vote bank. "Welfarism, like providing toilets, water, housing and electricity, has been better at breaking caste and community barriers," says a party insider. "The emergence of the *laabharthi* (beneficiary) vote is proof of that, especially among women who voted in large numbers for the BJP in UP."

WITH HINDUTVA YIELDING DIMINISHING RETURNS, THE BJP IS BANKING ON NATIONALISM AND WELFARISM TO ATTRACT VOTES

What this points to is a way beyond religious consolidation. There is a whole new aspirational class of voters who want job opportunities, better incomes and good governance. The emphatic win of the Aam Aadmi Party in Punjab has equally demonstrated this. Arvind Kejriwal's *inquilab* (revolution) is all about empowering the common man. The Congress emerged as the biggest loser in this election, coming out poorly in all the five states it contested in. These included Uttarakhand and Goa, where it should have won, and Punjab, which it should have retained. The left-of-centre space that the party symbolises, and its push for inclusive growth, do still have traction, but the current leadership is incapable of using that strength to galvanise voters. AAP may be aspiring to occupy that space after its victory in Punjab, but it has a long way to go before it can displace the Congress as the BJP's primary challenger. Nor can the BJP afford to rest on its laurels. Modi has shown that only hard work, clarity and single-minded pursuit of goals will yield dividends. The ruling party must continue to focus on development and progress if it wants to remain one. ■